

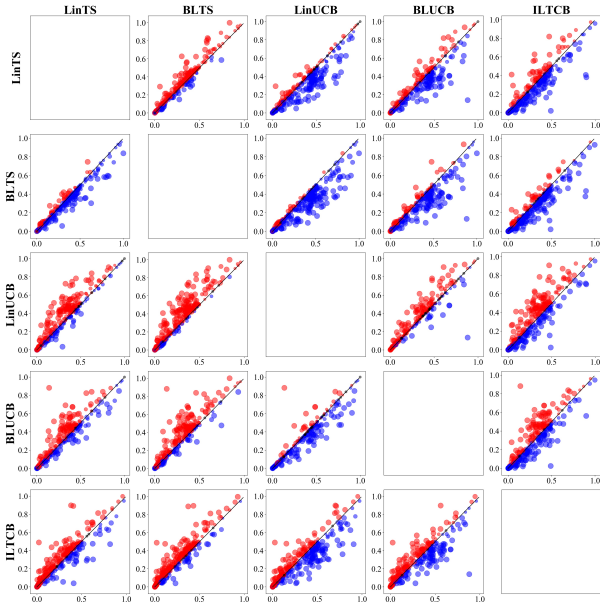


Figure 4: Comparing LinTS, BLTS, LinUCB, BLUCB, ILTCB on 300 datasets. BLUCB outperforms LinUCB. BLTS outperforms LinTS, LinUCB, BLUCB, ILTCB.

Closing Remarks

Contextual bandits are poised to play an important role in a wide range of applications: content recommendation in web-services, where the learner wants to personalize recommendations (arm) to the profile of a user (context) to maximize engagement (reward); online education platforms, where the learner wants to select a teaching method (arm) based on the characteristics of a student (context) in order to maximize the student’s scores (reward); and survey experiments, where the learner wants to learn what information or persuasion (arm) influences the responses (reward) of subjects as a function of their demographics, political beliefs, or other characteristics (context). In these settings, there are many potential sources of bias in estimation of outcome models, not only due to the inherent adaptive data collection, but also due to mismatch between the true data generating process and the outcome model assumptions, and due to prejudice in the training data in form of under-representation or over-representation of certain regions of the context space. To reduce bias, we have proposed new contextual bandit algorithms, BLTS and BLUCB, which build on linear contextual bandits LinTS and LinUCB respectively and improve them with balancing methods from the causal inference literature.

We derived the first regret bound analysis for linear contextual bandits with balancing and we showed linear contextual bandits with balancing match the theoretical guarantees of the linear contextual bandits with direct model estimation; namely that BLTS matches the regret bound of LinTS and BLUCB matches the regret bound of LinUCB. A synthetic example simulating covariate shift and model misspecification and a large-scale experiment with real multiclass classification datasets demonstrated the effectiveness of balancing

in contextual bandits, particularly when coupled with Thompson sampling.

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